

Tadia Siwisa- The Passionate Nobody

Yes, it is true. I am she: the passionate writer. I thought it fitting to write my self-introduction this way, for a writing course.

(Note: The tone of this short biography is factual, humorous, and metaphorical. I encourage the reader to approach it with optimism, a little “un-seriousness,” and an open mind. This is purely for your entertainment.)

A series of both fortunate and unfortunate events have unfolded since my birth. Oh, don't worry, this is not a sob story. I am not trying to win your heart over using sympathy as a tool. However... my father passed away when I was eight years old. Before that, all my grandparents, but one had passed, and then that last grandparent died shortly after my father. Yes, I became very acquainted with death at a young age.

But with death came many gifts; a treasure trove of books my father left behind, and a mind that turned inward, building many worlds through imagination. My coping mechanism became fun, play, and recreating my inner worlds in reality. So my childhood turned into a long “bucket list” of everything I felt I needed to do and an unchecked impulsivity to manifest each inner desire or simply die trying. (Hmmm now that I write this, I realize perhaps I felt an urgency to do these things because I believed death was chasing me)

Back to the story.

My childhood was full of ideas. I would convince my mother why we had to make them happen. (Mind you, these ideas were never simple or cheap.) I wanted to learn trombone because it looked “cool.” I demanded a tennis coach because I was convinced it was my destiny to beat Serena Williams one day. I wanted to do gymnastics because I watched a movie about an underdog who finally got the success she deserved, I felt I was destined for that too.

At school, I rallied kids to join my crazy schemes: organizing a free marketplace in the sand-pit at aftercare, or directing short plays, gathering audiences for my “productions.” I became a negotiator with adults, a wannabe businesswoman, and a director of little childhood theatrics. I tried every sport I could think of, but settled on Netball and Athletics, where I actually had some talent.

High school came with more restrictions — puberty, homework, social groups, boys, sport becoming serious. But this didn't stop the urgent need to follow my heart. Internally, I always had this burning desire: inspiration would hit hard, the need to actualize my inner world in reality was always overwhelming, and at all times I always felt nothing was impossible. Being exposed to death's reality so young made me realize how short life is, so I was determined to live. There was always urgency behind my desires.

Yes, I changed dreams constantly. My poor mother eventually gave up trying to control me because every denial ended in dramatic self-isolation and extreme anger. Starving myself and threatening disappearance, that was my protest. “No” was not in my vocabulary. Instead I challenged everything. Every “you can't” became “I will show you.” Obstacles became skills I was ready to acquire; challenges were training grounds.

Then, university. I completed a degree in Economics and Statistics. There I discovered my natural instincts for pattern recognition, analysis, and strategic thinking. I also discovered philosophy, which became my obsession. I ranked among the top 20 of my cohort. And there, during this time, I discovered writing.

In a university writing competition, I came in second. The essay I submitted was essentially one extended metaphor, weaving ideas, concepts, and analysis together. I didn't know then what I was doing consciously; it was instinctual. Since that moment, I couldn't stop writing. Yes!, I found another outlet to build inner worlds into reality again.

Since leaving the education system, I've had many lives. Started a tutoring business, I travelled to several countries. Worked for Disney English in Chengdu. Experienced COVID. Started a business (failed). Worked in fuel (hated it). Did postgraduate studies (abandoned them). Started another business (failed). Got a data science certificate (loved). Worked as a research analyst (enjoyed it, but needed more).

All the while, I kept writing, privately, obsessively and instinctively.

I dove into philosophy again, disagreed with Aristotle, gave a slight nod to Karl Marx for predicting the effects of Capitalism, then left before he could confuse me.

Jung resonated with my soul.

Dostoyevsky lit fires in my mind but also paralyzed me.

Kafka confused me entirely.

Bukowski became a spirit animal.

And now Nietzsche keeps calling.

And here I am.

Back in China.

Writing this unconventional self-introduction for a writing course I chose because I am genuinely frustrated by how little attention writing receives. I believe writing gives voice to people who've never found theirs, to those who want to create but don't know what to build. Writing is a medium of expression.

In many cultures, creativity is not viewed as "useful" or "practical." For those brave enough to be different in such societies, writing is for them. And I believe it is my duty to teach students not only grammar or vocabulary, but how to build ideas, how to form unique thoughts from personal experience and how to transfer them onto paper. I believe words, arranged in the right order can have a lasting impact. This is a skill I would be honoured to teach my students and to spark in them a tiny flame of passion. The world needs more writers. The world needs more cultural exchange and more individuality in this social-media age.

Now, we are slowly approaching the end of my rambling. I know I have broken the conventional rules of English and literature. But nothing makes sense anyways and because this is how I am, perhaps it

does make sense.

So, who am I? I am not one thing, I am many things.

I grew up hearing: “Jack of all trades is a master of none.” Thank goodness I never listened, because the full quote is: “Jack of all trades, master of none — but oftentimes better than a master of one.” I would rather be the best analyst among English teachers and the best English teacher among analysts. How lovely it is to be different in a world that demands conformity

So, what are my current thoughts on life and death?

I believe a life well lived doesn't fear death. Instead, death becomes a respectful spectator, pausing to watch a performance so compelling that it demands to see the next act. Thus, death becomes the reward: a deep peaceful slumber waiting for you as compensation for having emptied every last drop of life within you.

(And for the thinkers: it shall be noted that this perspective originated from the protagonist and writer of this piece, just as the thinker is also the observer of their own life).

Although death continues to chase me, I occasionally turn around and negotiate for time to slow down.

As you can see: I have lived many lifetimes in one and I continue to follow my heart's desires. I agree with Oscar Wilde when he said: “If you know exactly what you want to be in life, you will become it; that is your punishment.”-I'll leave that for you to decipher.

So, my fellow reader, if there is one thing you must know about me, it is this;

“Understand me, I'm not like an ordinary world, I have my madness. I live in another dimension and I do not have time for things that have no soul.”- Charles Bukowski

I wonder what will happen next.

Wait.

...I feel something is stirring.